Laura Fermi. “We at once decided to leave Italy as soon as possible.” Her husband, Enrico, was the pride of Italian physics, one of the foremost experts on both theoretical and experimental nuclear physics in the world. But with Italy unsafe for the family of a Catholic man and a Jewish woman, Enrico and Laura quietly made plans to leave. Their plans were complicated by Mussolini’s fascist economic policy, which made it illegal to take more than pocket change out of Italy. Then Niels Bohr intervened. When Fermi came to Copenhagen for a conference that summer, Bohr took him aside and—breaking an unwritten rule of the physics community—told Fermi that his name was in the running for a Nobel Prize that year. Would the prize, which came with a $1 million cash award and an excuse to travel abroad, be useful this year, Bohr asked? Or would another time be more convenient, given the political situation? Fermi told Bohr that this year would be a particularly good time for the prize. Returning home, Fermi found that the Italian government had confiscated all Jewish passports, including Laura’s; pulling a few strings, he managed to get her passport back in time to attend the Nobel ceremony in Stockholm. After Stockholm, the Fermis went to Copenhagen to visit Bohr, and, finding the wheels of American immigration greased by the words “Nobel Prize winner,” they set sail for Manhattan just before Christmas, arriving on January 2, 1939.

Well-established physicists like Einstein, Born, and Fermi were often able to secure new jobs in their new countries before they had even arrived. But the lives of students and younger researchers were far more thoroughly disrupted. “My heart aches at the thought of the young ones,” Einstein wrote to Born in 1933. Einstein was soon involved with a British-led effort to help the academic victims of the Nazi regime, which met with some success. By the time Hitler invaded Poland and started World War II on September 1, 1939, more than a hundred physicists had emigrated from the European continent to the United States and the UK—some of the younger ones simply fleeing, refugees without the promise of a job in their new country, coming with a single small bag across the Channel or the Atlantic. Some came with nothing. Some never came at all.